How to mix the colour and its shades

You will not get white paint by mixing red, yellow and blue. You need a white pigment, or you let white paper or ground show through. With light it is different. A suitable combination of coloured lights can produce a white impression. A palette and a spotlight simply do not share the same procedure.

Every white is a little different. **Titanium white** usually covers well and lightens mixtures strongly. More translucent whites behave differently and the kind of paint matters too.

What to prepare

White
For ordinary work with acrylic, titanium white can be the base.

Yellow or ochre
For warmer, creamy shades.

Brown
In tiny doses for broken whites.

Blue
For a cool tint.

Red or magenta
For a barely noticeable pink tinge.

Black
Really just a little, for off-white greys.

An unpainted spot is white too

With watercolour a white spot can arise by leaving the paper unpainted. With acrylic, on the other hand, you can apply white in a thick layer.

White therefore need not mean "there is nothing there". Sometimes it is the paper itself, at other times a proper layer of paint.

What the additions do

Yellow
Shifts toward cream. Add by the tip.
→

Ochre
Shifts toward ivory, softer and warmer.
→

Brown
Shifts toward broken white, gently earthy.
→

Blue
Shifts toward cool, bluish.
→

Red
Shifts toward pinkish white. Only a trace.
→

Black
Turns grey. The tip of a brush is enough.
→

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Ten whites to try

For these mixtures start with a larger heap of white and add only a trace of the other pigment. **Half and half is no longer a lightly tinted white**, but a completely different company. Take the ratios as a starting point for trying.

Pure white

White straight from the tube, a clean brush and a clean palette.

Cream

White and a tiny trace of yellow or ochre.

Ivory

White and a trace of ochre. According to the result even less brown.

Warm broken white

White and a tiny amount of warm brown.

Cool off-white

White and a barely noticeable trace of blue.

Pinkish white

White and a tiny amount of red or magenta.

Whitish grey

White and the tip of a brush of black.

Snow

Clean and slightly cool. Take care it doesn't turn blue.

Milk

Soft and smooth. Warmer than snow.

Bone

Natural and matte, close to linen.

Pearl and porcelain

A pearly look is created with pearlescent paint or medium. **White alone will not create glossy reflections.**

Names like milk, snow or porcelain are not exact recipes. Two manufacturers agree on ivory about as much as two families on the right potato salad. Compare samples side by side and in the same light.

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